The music helps to keep the romance of guns and gangsterism alive among the young. Moosewala's last song, 'Last Ride', has lines romanticising the lives of gangsters who died young—a motto straight out of Black American writer Willard Motley's 1947 cult novel, *Knock On Any Door*: "Live fast, die young, and have a good-looking corpse." Punjab's gun-toters may not have read the novel, but a global gangsta spirit has washed over them. They are often decked out in T-shirts with such legends, or images idolising rebels who died young, including freedom fighters Udham Singh, Bhagat Singh, Kartar Singh Saraba; Latin American revolutionary Che Guevara; and, of course, Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale. From there to gangsta rap may sound a bit of a leap, but the connection is organic. It wasn't just Moosewala. His rival Mankirat Aulakh had songs like 'Ath Rafflan' (Eight Rifles) and 'Do Rafflan' (Two Rifles), Karan Aujla did 'Mitran Da Gangster Scene', Nav Sandhu had 'Gangster Yaar'.... It came to a point where Amarinder, as CM, had to actively put the leash on singers, including Moosewala and Aulakh, for brandishing guns and promoting violence. The Punjab and Haryana High Court too directed police to ensure no songs glorifying liquor, drugs or violence were played at live shows.

HARVEST OF GUNS

Police data show Punjab has over 425,000 licensed arms—the state police itself has less than 125,000—not counting the unlicensed ones. These are not the countrymade pistols one may find in UP or Bihar. Moosewala—whose debut song as lyricist had the famous line *Derhndiya hikka oh license nahio lehnde* (those who have to pierce the rival's chest need no licence)—was gunned down with a Russian AN-94, one of the most sophisticated pieces of ordnance out there. Amarinder blames Pakistan's ISI for using drones to offload arms and ammunition (along with drugs) in border areas. Officials say at least 20 drone-based consignments have been detected since September 2019. Punjab, therefore, is awash with Beretta and Glock 17 pistols, C30R assault rifles, rocket-propelled grenades—and everything in between. The AN-94, a double-burst assault rifle with a 1,800-bullets-per-minute fire rate, is so complex a weapon, requiring equally complex skills to operate, that very few security agen-

THE CANADIAN CONNECTION

Punjab Police is gradually zeroing in on the role of Toronto-based ganglord Goldy Brar and seeking his extradition. In the past few years, Canada has become a safe hideout for Punjab's gangsters, who use social media and virtual phones to conduct their operations remotely. Another name popping up on the register is that of Lakhbir Singh Landa. In 2018, he had fled to Canada after a series of cases piled up against him, including those of murder, extortion and robbery. The latest on that list: he was the one who executed the rocket-propelled grenade attack on Punjab Police's intel HQ in Mohali, apparently at the behest of Khalistani militant-cum-gangster Harinder Singh Rinda. Over 30 gangsters are suspected to have fled to the western nation.

The issue escalated when a National Investigation Agency team visited Ottawa in 2021 and met with Canadian officials. India has asked Canada to deny visas to gangsters from Punjab. The challenge is that gangsters use loopholes in the Indian system to get forged documents and procure necessary clearances. Indian requests for the extradition of gangsters—four times that for terrorists—routinely remain pending, say officials.

Security agencies believe the Khalistan Tiger Force (KTF) organises camps in Canada to train chosen gangsters in the use of sophisticated weapons. On their return, they pass on the knowhow to many of their cohorts. Canada, with its liberal arms policy, offers fertile ground for a flourishing Punjabi-Canadian underground—the Dhak-Duhre, Sanghera, Malhi-Buttar and Kang family gangs are part of that. They often engage with Punjab-based gangs—giving them assignments of targeted killings, extortion, drug trafficking—and help them reach Canada and settle with local gangs.

They are a headache for the Canadian authorities too. Last year, in a major crackdown on the drug trade, the majority of those arrested were Punjabis. The headache, naturally, spreads to Punjab. Many fugitive gangsters are linking up with known smuggler networks. The biggest catch so far for the state police have been Devinder Dev, Kamaljit Chauhan and Amarinder Singh Chhina—all Canadian drug gang members who had used Punjab as the base to transport drugs to Canada, the US and Australia. Thus, Punjab becomes a transit point for drugs emanating from the Golden Crescent countries: Afghanistan and Pakistan. Canadian gangs are interested in 'importing' cheap heroin from Afghanistan via Pakistan and Punjab, and 'exporting' refined drugs everywhere—including Punjab. The state is caught in a vicious loop.